PRIORITY 16 OF 33 · SCORE 3.0

NASA

NASA spends most of its budget on a few very large contracts, where fraud is about cost mischarging that public data cannot see. The public-data opening is small business research money (SBIR/STTR) and the supplier base under the large primes, where the SBA checks apply.

INVESTIGATIONS WE PROPOSE

- **NASA-1** Duplicate SBIR awards. **First prototype.**
- **NASA-2** Award mills (many Phase I, no Phase II).
- **NASA-3** Suppliers under large primes tied to excluded parties.

EXPOSURE

- $23B in outlays in FY2026.
- SBIR/STTR duplicate funding and misuse are recurring NASA OIG cases; GAO found about $445M in possibly duplicative SBIR awards across agencies.

PUBLIC DATA WE USE

- **SBIR.gov** award data; **NASA TechPort** project data.
- **FPDS / USAspending** contracts and subawards.
- **SAM.gov** entities and exclusions; NASA OIG reports.

HOW WE DETECT IT

1. **Duplicate research awards** across agencies (shared with Energy and NSF).
2. **Award-mill firms:** firms with many SBIR Phase I awards and no Phase II or commercialization record.
3. **Supplier screen:** subcontractors under large primes tied to excluded parties or sharing addresses with the prime.

FIRST PROTOTYPE

Include NASA in the cross-agency SBIR duplicate-award screen.

SCORECARD

Fraud savings identified
● Pending

Phase 1 window
Weeks 9–12
Jan 11, 2027 to Feb 5, 2027

Workstream
Shared screens

FY2026 outlays
$22.9B · budget rank 19

Leads go to
NASA OIG

WHY PRIORITY 16

Exposure	●●○○○
Public data	●●●●○
SBA method fit	●●●●○
Actionability	●●○○○

OUR REVIEW, DELIVERED WEEK 12

NASA SBIR/STTR in the duplicate-award screen; award mill check; supplier screen on subawards under the largest primes.

Every lead goes to an Inspector General or DOJ as a referral package with sources and caveats. Nothing is published.

WHAT WE ASK OF NASA

Phase 2 data: Full proposals and budgets, PI current-and-pending support.

What it enables: Duplicate funding at the proposal level.

Access route: Each OIG.

LIMITS

Cost-plus contract mischarging and labor fraud are invisible in public data.

SOURCES

- GAO-24-105470: SBIR/STTR fraud vulnerabilities
- SBIR.gov awards data
- USAspending agency profiles (FY2026 outlays)

Scores and plans are our judgment from public sources. Risk indicators are leads for Inspectors General or DOJ, not accusations.

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